western Pacific Ocean. The new weapons systems included antiship ballistic missiles, attack submarines, stealth fighters, swarming missile boats, and the like.[28] During the same period, in 1994, the first North Korean nuclear crisis occurred, raising the specter of US military strikes on the Korean Peninsula and spurring diplomatic negotiations between the Clinton administration and the Kim regime that led to the so-called Agreed Framework to halt Pyongyang's nuclear development program in exchange for two light-water nuclear reactors.

Though the 9/11 terror attacks consumed the attention and energies of the Bush administration during the first decade of the twenty-first century, China's undeniable growth, the discovery of North Korean cheating on the Agreed Framework, and a breakthrough in US-India relations pushed Washington to begin focusing more on the Indo-Pacific region.[29] Much effort was spent on attempting to balance America's long-standing alliance commitments with the rising influence of China, seeking ever closer cooperation with Beijing so as to turn it into a willing partner in maintaining stability. Central to this strategy was the establishment of the "Strategic and Economic Dialogue" between the top officials in Washington and Beijing, an attempt that some compared the forging of a G-2 condominium to settle major global issues.[30] As for North Korea, the Bush administration initiated the Six-Party Talks mechanism as a multilateral diplomatic approach for solving the peninsula's nuclear crisis.

The 2008 financial crisis threw a wrench into Washington's plans, convincing Chinese leaders that their communist system was superior to America's dangerously out-of-control capitalist model. This led to growing hubris on the part of top Chinese Communist Party (CCP) officials, like then Chinese president Hu Jintao, and a belief that China would soon displace American power in Asia. By the end of Bush's second term, little progress had come of the G-2, and Pyongyang had claimed its first nuclear detonation. These two poles, China and North Korea, increasingly shaped US strategy in the region, challenging prior assumptions about Asia's peaceful rise and questioning the